Retirement Plan Access and Participation Among Private-Sector Workers, 2010–2024

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1 Introduction

This exercise constructs annual measures of retirement plan *access* and *participation* among private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64 using the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC) from 2010 through 2024. Access refers to whether an employer offers a retirement plan, while participation refers to whether the worker is included in that plan. Using IPUMS-CPS microdata, I construct weighted annual estimates and document the sample construction and measurement choices used to produce a transparent and replicable time series of retirement plan coverage.

2 Sample Construction

The analysis uses microdata from the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC) for survey years 2010 through 2024. The unit of observation is the individual respondent. To construct the analytic sample, I apply a series of restrictions that align the sample with the population of interest: private-sector workers of working age.

First, the sample is restricted to individuals ages 20–64 using the variable `AGE`. This restriction focuses the analysis on the working-age population while excluding younger respondents who are typically not fully attached to the labor force and older individuals who are more likely to be retired.

Second, I restrict the sample to individuals who are currently employed using the CPS employment-status variable `EMPSTAT`. Respondents coded as `EMPSTAT = 10` ("at work") or `EMPSTAT = 12` ("has job, not at work last week") are classified as employed and retained in the sample. Individuals who are unemployed or not in the labor force are excluded.

Third, among employed individuals I restrict the sample to private-sector wage-and-salary workers using the class-of-worker variable `CLASSWKR`. In this extract, the relevant category corresponds to code 21, which represents private wage-and-salary workers. Self-employed individuals, government workers, unpaid family workers, and other employment categories are excluded. This restriction ensures that the denominator corresponds to workers who could plausibly receive an employer-sponsored retirement plan from a private-sector employer.

After applying these restrictions, the resulting analytic sample consists of private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64 observed in the CPS ASEC between 2010 and 2024.

3 Measurement of Retirement Plan Access and Participation

Retirement plan access and participation are measured using CPS ASEC questions regarding employer-sponsored pension or retirement plans. The analysis distinguishes between two related but conceptually distinct outcomes: whether a worker has access to a retirement plan offered by their employer and whether the worker actually participates in such a plan.

Access is measured using the variable `UH_PENPLAN_A1`, which indicates whether the respondent's employer offers a pension or retirement plan for any of its employees. In the CPS questionnaire, respondents are asked whether their employer provides such a plan. Workers who respond affirmatively are coded as having access to a retirement plan. In the analysis, access is coded as a binary indicator equal to 1 if `UH_PENPLAN_A1 = 1` and 0 if `UH_PENPLAN_A1 = 2`.

Participation is measured using two CPS variables. First, the variable `UH_PENSINCL_A1` indicates whether the respondent is included in the employer's pension or retirement plan. This variable is used to construct a conditional participation measure among workers whose employers offer a plan. Conditional participation is coded as 1 if `UH_PENSINCL_A1 = 1` and 0 if `UH_PENSINCL_A1 = 2`.

Second, the variable `PENSION` provides an additional indicator of whether the worker is covered by a pension plan at work. This variable is used as a cross-check when constructing an unconditional participation measure. In the unconditional measure, participation is coded as 1 if `PENSION = 3` and 0 otherwise.

Together, these variables allow the analysis to distinguish between workers whose employers offer retirement plans and workers who are actually enrolled in those plans.

4 Weighting

All estimates are calculated using the CPS ASEC person weight `ASECWT`. The CPS ASEC is a complex survey designed to represent the U.S. population, and the person weight adjusts for the survey's sampling design, differential probabilities of selection, and nonresponse. Applying `ASECWT` ensures that computed statistics represent population-level estimates rather than simple averages from the raw survey sample.

In practice, the weight is applied when computing all annual means and proportions. As a result, reported access and participation rates should be interpreted as estimates for the national population of private-sector wage-and-salary workers ages 20–64.

5 Treatment of Missing or Ambiguous Responses

The CPS variables used in the analysis contain categories for responses that are not in universe or otherwise missing. In constructing the outcome measures, responses coded as "not in universe" are treated as zero when calculating weighted means for the full analytic sample. This approach preserves a consistent denominator when computing access and participation rates.

For example, when constructing the access variable from `UH_PENPLAN_A1`, responses indicating that a worker's employer does not offer a retirement plan are coded as 0, while affirmative responses are coded as 1. Observations coded as not in universe are treated as zero in the weighted calculation so that workers without access remain part of the denominator.

Similarly, when constructing participation measures, responses indicating nonparticipation are coded as 0, while affirmative responses are coded as 1. Conditional participation is evaluated among workers with access to an employer-sponsored plan, while the unconditional measure uses the broader pension coverage variable for validation and consistency checks.

These choices follow the logic implemented in the analysis code and ensure that annual estimates are constructed consistently across survey years.

6 Implications of the 2015 CPS ASEC Redesign

In 2015 the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC) implemented a redesigned questionnaire and processing system intended to improve the measurement of income and program participation. The redesign introduced new income questions, revised survey sequencing, and updated data processing methods. As a result, several income-related measures in the CPS ASEC exhibit structural differences beginning with the 2015 survey.

Although retirement plan access and participation are not direct income measures, the redesign can still affect interpretation of time-series estimates. Changes in questionnaire structure and survey administration may alter how respondents understand or answer questions about employer benefits, including pension and retirement plan coverage. Consequently, observed differences in retirement plan access or participation around 2015 may partly reflect measurement changes rather than purely economic or institutional trends.

For this reason, estimates spanning the 2010–2024 period should be interpreted with awareness of the 2015 CPS ASEC redesign. When analyzing trends across this boundary, it is important to consider the possibility of a break in series driven by survey methodology rather than underlying changes in retirement plan coverage.

A Appendix Figures and Variable Definitions

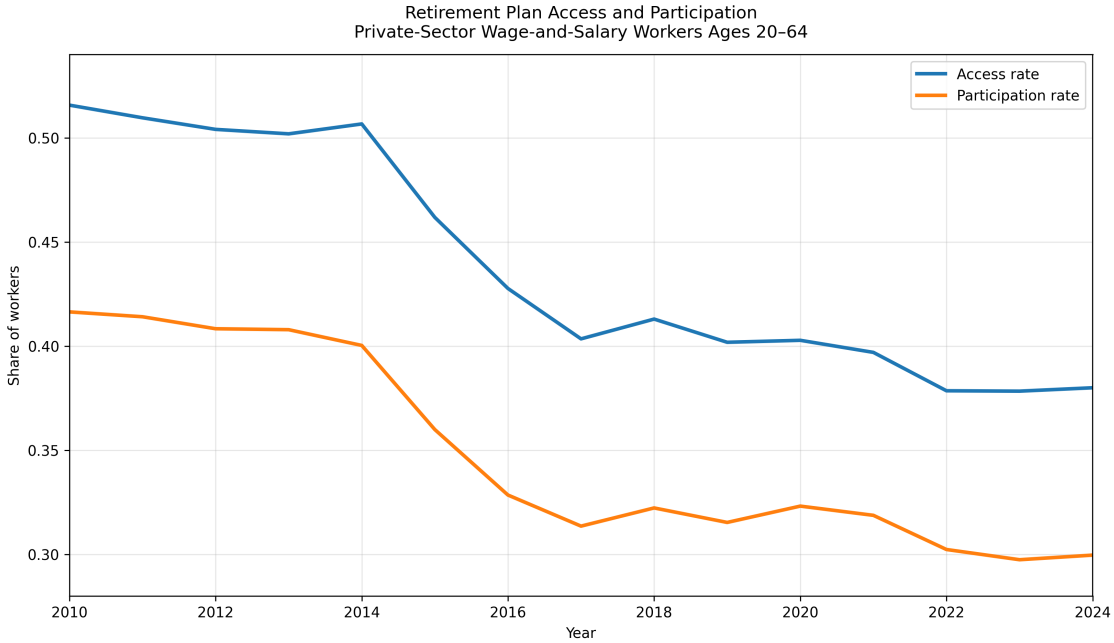

Figure 1: Retirement plan access and participation among private-sector workers ages 20–64, 2010–2024.

Standard errors and confidence intervals were computed in the analysis workflow but are not displayed in the main figure for visual clarity since they were so small to the extent of being invisible.

A.1 Variable Definitions and Coding

Table 1 documents the variables used to define the analytic sample, construct the main outcomes, and validate consistency checks in the Component 1 workflow.

Table 1: Variable definitions and coding for Component 1 analysis

Variable name	Role in analysis	Official label	Coding used in this project	Notes / interpretation
`YEAR`	Sample restriction; grouping	Survey year	Keep 2010–2024; group by year	Used to construct annual estimates
`AGE`	Sample restriction	Age	Keep 20–64	Working-age adults
`EMPSTAT`	Sample restriction	Employment status	Keep 10 (at work) and 12 (has job, not at work last week)	Excludes unemployed and NILF
`CLASSWKR`	Sample restriction	Class of worker	Keep 21 (private wage/salary)	Other private codes are not observed in this extract
`ASECWT`	Weighting	ASEC person weight	Used as person-level weight in all annual estimates	Weights used in means and SEs
`UH_PENPLAN_A1`	Access construction	Existence of pension plan by employer, 1980–2025	`access`=1 if 1; `access`=0 if 2	NIU treated as zero in weighted means
`UH_PENSINCL_A1`	Conditional participation	Included in pension plan at work, 1980–2025	`participation_conditional`=1 if 1; =0 if 2	Computed among `access`=1
`PENSION`	Unconditional participation; validation	Pension plan at work	`participation_unconditional`=1 if 3; =0 if 1 or 2	Cross-checks access/participation coding
`access`	Derived outcome	Constructed	Derived from `UH_PENPLAN_A1`	Used for access rate and denominator for conditional participation
`participation_unconditional`	Derived outcome	Constructed	Derived from `PENSION`	Used in final tables and figures
`participation_conditional`	Derived outcome	Constructed	Derived from `UH_PENSINCL_A1`	Used in final tables and figures

Component 2: Summary of Research Findings

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This paper examines an important financial risk facing older households: the income shock that can occur when one spouse dies. In the United States, many married couples depend heavily on Social Security benefits in retirement. When a spouse dies, however, the household typically loses one of those benefit checks, even though many of the household's expenses remain unchanged. As a result, surviving spouses—most often widows—can experience a sharp decline in financial resources. The research paper by Slavov asks whether the timing of Social Security claiming decisions made earlier in retirement can reduce the financial strain that surviving spouses face after widowhood.[1]

The study focuses on how the claiming behavior of the primary earner—typically the husband in older cohorts—affects the financial well-being of the surviving spouse. Under Social Security rules, workers receive larger monthly payments if they delay claiming benefits beyond the earliest eligibility age. These higher benefits also raise the survivor benefit that a spouse can receive after the worker dies. Because widows are generally entitled to the larger of their own benefit or their deceased spouse's benefit, delayed claiming by the husband can increase the income available to the widow later in life.

To study this issue, the author uses survey data that track older Americans' Social Security claiming behavior, marital histories, and income. The analysis compares households in which husbands claim benefits early with those in which husbands delay claiming benefits until full retirement age or later. Rather than focusing only on average income levels in retirement, the study examines the change in household income that occurs when widowhood begins. This approach allows the author to measure more precisely the financial shock that surviving spouses experience.

The results show that delayed claiming significantly reduces the financial shock associated with widowhood. When husbands postpone claiming Social Security benefits, their higher monthly payments translate into larger survivor benefits for their wives. As a result, widows experience a smaller drop in income after their spouse dies. In effect, a decision made earlier in retirement—when to begin collecting Social Security—can shape financial security many years later.

These findings carry important implications for retirement planning and policy. Many households claim benefits as soon as they become eligible, often due to health concerns or immediate financial needs. However, early claiming can leave surviving spouses financially vulnerable. Encour-

[1] Sita N. Slavov, "The Impact of Spousal Social Security Claiming Decisions on the Financial Shock of Widowhood," Working Paper No. 34612 (Cambridge, MA: National Bureau of Economic Research, 2025), https://doi.org/10.3386/w34612.

aging households to consider survivor protection when making claiming decisions could therefore improve long-term financial security for widows.

More broadly, the paper highlights the role of Social Security not only as a retirement income program but also as a form of survivor insurance. Claiming decisions are often framed as individual choices, yet they can shape the financial stability of an entire household. By showing that delayed claiming can cushion the economic impact of widowhood, the study contributes to policy discussions about how Social Security rules influence retirement behavior and financial well-being later in life.